

PRODUCT TEARDOWN

Cult.Fit

won the gym. then the gym
stopped mattering.

May 2026

COMPANY SNAPSHOT

A unicorn built on group fitness - now racing six battles simultaneously against six focused specialists.

Founded 2016 by Mukesh Bansal and Ankit Nagori, Cult.Fit grew from a single fitness studio into a six-vertical health platform backed by \$650M+. By 2019 it was India's largest fitness chain. By 2022 it is fighting to justify the health OS thesis.

SCALE (AS OF FY2022)

270+ centers, 18 cities

India's largest chain of group fitness studios. 10-12 million registered users across all verticals. Cult.Live claimed 1.5M+ digital subscribers at peak (2021).

CAPITAL RAISED

~\$650M total funding

Backed by Accel, Tiger Global, Temasek, and Trifecta. Achieved unicorn status in 2019 at ~\$1.5B valuation. FY2022 net loss: ~INR 800 crore on INR 650 crore revenue.

THE THESIS

6 verticals, 1 subscription

Cult.Fit (gyms), Eat.fit (food), Mind.fit (mental health), Care.Fit (healthcare), Whole.Fit (grocery), and Cult Sports (equipment) - all under one Cult Pass umbrella.

ACT 01

The Win

01

CATEGORY CREATION

Cult didn't compete with gyms - it made gyms obsolete by selling the workout as a social experience with a score.

Traditional gyms sell equipment access. Cult.Fit sold a class, a trainer, an energy score, and 18 people sweating alongside you. Premium pricing at Rs 1,999-2,499/month felt like belonging - not a membership fee.

THE HOOK

Trainer-led group formats, 30+ styles

Choreographed HIIT, yoga, boxing, dance, and cycling sessions. Group accountability and social proof from 18 people in the same session beats solo treadmill motivation in every user cohort.

THE RETENTION MECHANIC

Energy Meter + live rank + streak

Live movement tracking generated a class rank visible during the session. Users returned not just for fitness but to beat last week's score. Gamification created the habit loop no gym competitor could replicate.

THE LOCK-IN

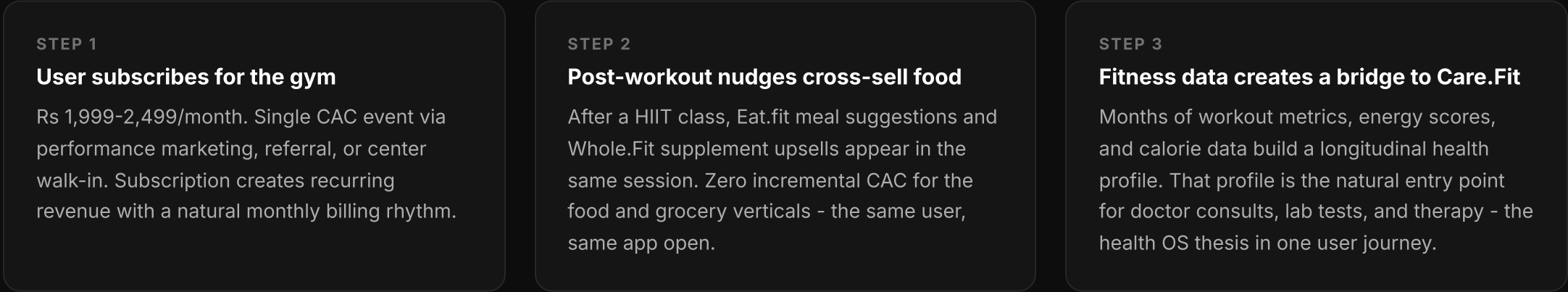
Monthly subscription, not pay-per-class

Sunk-cost psychology drives attendance when users have prepaid. At Rs 1,999-2,499/month, Cult.Fit's churn was structurally lower than drop-in gym models - and every renewal was an upsell door into five other verticals.

BUSINESS MODEL

One CAC event. Five upsell doors. The subscription flywheel only works if the gym is the entry point - and stays the entry point.

Cult.Fit's integration thesis is elegant: acquire a user once through the gym, cross-sell food, healthcare, mental wellness, grocery, and equipment inside the same app. The economics only compound if the gym subscription never breaks.



ACT 02

The Trap

02

THE FORCING FUNCTION

COVID didn't just close 270 centers - it exposed that the entire flywheel depended on an asset that could be shut by a government order.

When lockdowns hit in March 2020, Cult.Fit's primary revenue engine went to zero overnight. Revenue fell from ~INR 400 crore in FY2020 to INR 226 crore in FY2021 - a 40%+ collapse. Net losses hit INR 856 crore that year on less than INR 230 crore of revenue.

THE FINANCIAL IMPACT (FY2021)**Revenue -43%, losses exceed revenue**

INR 226 crore in revenue against INR 856 crore in net losses. Every rupee earned was consumed 3.8x over by a cost structure built for 270 physical centers that were now shut. Monthly burn peaked at ~INR 70-80 crore.

THE FALLOUT**~1,000+ layoffs in 2020**

Approximately 15-20% of the 5,000-person workforce was cut in mid-2020. Center-based operations staff bore the brunt. Refund disputes over paused memberships became a PR crisis on Twitter and Reddit India communities.

THE STRUCTURAL PROBLEM

Unlike a SaaS company, Cult.Fit's cost base is almost entirely fixed: gym leases, trainer salaries, equipment amortization. Revenue stopped. Costs did not. The integration thesis had no digital fallback at scale when the offline anchor disappeared.

DIGITAL RESPONSE

Cult.Live reached 1.5M digital subscribers - then most of them churned the moment the gyms reopened.

Cult.Live's rapid growth during lockdowns was real - but it was demand displacement, not new demand creation. When centers reopened in 2021-22, Cult.Live retention fell sharply. The digital product that saved the company is now cannibalizing the offline recovery.

CULT.LIVE (PEAK 2021)

~1.5M subscribers at Rs 499-999/month

Live + on-demand workout library. Strong product technically. But digital ARPU at Rs 8,000-12,000/year is structurally lower than the Rs 18,000-22,000/year offline pass - and the cost to build and maintain is similar.

THE PROBLEM

YouTube is free. Nike Training Club is free.

Peloton has hardware lock-in. Nike Training Club has a global brand. YouTube has 10,000 fitness creators with millions of free subscribers. Cult.Live's premium pricing needs to deliver something none of them can - and community alone is not enough.

THE TENSION

Online cannibalizes the offline recovery

A subscriber who pays Rs 800/month for Cult.Live has no financial incentive to return to a Rs 2,000/month center pass. The digital product that survived COVID is now competing with the business model it was built to support.

COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE

Six verticals means six category battles - each against a specialist running on no execution drag from the other five.

The integration thesis only holds if Cult.Fit wins or stays competitive in every vertical. In reality, each category has at least one well-funded specialist that does the single thing better - with no multi-product complexity slowing them down.

CULT.FIT - GROUP FITNESS

vs. Fitternity, Gold's Gym

Fitternity offers 8,000+ studio partners asset-light. Traditional gym chains renegotiated COVID leases Cult.Fit couldn't match. Cult's format IP is real - but the cost structure gap is growing.

EAT.FIT - FOOD DELIVERY

vs. Swiggy, Zomato

Swiggy and Zomato have 300,000+ restaurant partners, 30-minute delivery, and a loyalty program. Eat.fit's macro-transparency angle is genuinely differentiated - but insufficient against density and speed at scale.

CARE.FIT - HEALTHCARE

vs. Practo, Apollo 24/7

Practo has 20M+ patients and 10 years of doctor-trust equity. Apollo has physical network credibility. Healthcare is a trust purchase - entering it as a gym app is a brand problem, not a product problem.

MIND.FIT - MENTAL WELLNESS

vs. YourDOST, Wysa

Mental health requires deep practitioner trust. YourDOST and Wysa built therapist networks and credibility specifically for this context. Cult.Fit is a gym app entering a category that demands a different kind of brand entirely.

WHOLE.FIT - GROCERY

vs. BigBasket, Zepto

Q-commerce players like Zepto deliver clean-label groceries in 10 minutes. BigBasket has selection scale. Whole.Fit's premium positioning narrowed the addressable market to a niche Cult.Fit couldn't sustain - wound down by 2022-23.

CULT SPORTS - EQUIPMENT

vs. Decathlon, Amazon

Decathlon wins on price and selection across 80+ India stores. Amazon on convenience. Cult Sports competes on brand within a captive gym-member base - but captive doesn't mean loyal when Decathlon is cheaper by 30%.

FINANCIAL REALITY

Losses exceeding revenue two years running: the multi-vertical bet is burning \$650M of investor capital without a clear path to breakeven.

FY2022 net loss was ~INR 800 crore on INR 650 crore revenue - a burn ratio that signals the integration thesis is not yet creating operating leverage. Running six simultaneous businesses costs more than any single vertical can ever subsidize.

COST STRUCTURE**Fixed costs, variable revenue**

Gym leases, trainer salaries, and equipment carry full cost regardless of occupancy. A 60% attendance month and a 30% month share nearly identical cost bases. Food delivery and healthcare add separate supply-chain layers on top.

REVENUE MIX (EST. FY2022)**Subscriptions are core, rest is transactional**

Cult.Fit gym passes: ~50-55% of revenue.
Eat.fit delivery and Cult Sports: ~20-25%.
Care.Fit and digital subscriptions: ~20-25%.
Transactional verticals carry thin margins and no subscription lock-in.

THE ONE EXIT**Mature centers are unit-positive**

Management claims Cult.Fit centers older than 3 years operate at positive unit economics. New centers need 12-18 months to reach breakeven. The rationalization from 300+ to ~220 centers by 2023-24 was a direct response to this math.

ACT 03

The Product

03

FEATURE ANALYSIS - CULT.FIT

Energy Meter is the product's best retention mechanic - and its UX breaks at the exact moment the feedback loop should matter most.

Live movement tracking and class rank create genuine gamified accountability. But the score is unreadable mid-workout, the Fitness Journey shows past classes without recommending next steps, and a massive content library with no navigation AI overwhelms new users.

WORKS

Live rank drives repeat bookings

Streak tracking and class rank create social accountability that transcends the workout itself. Users book again to defend position - not just for fitness.

BROKEN

Score unreadable during the class

Energy meter appears on a small display mid-HIIT. In an active session, no user can read or act on the feedback. The most valuable data moment in the experience is invisible when it matters.

MISSING

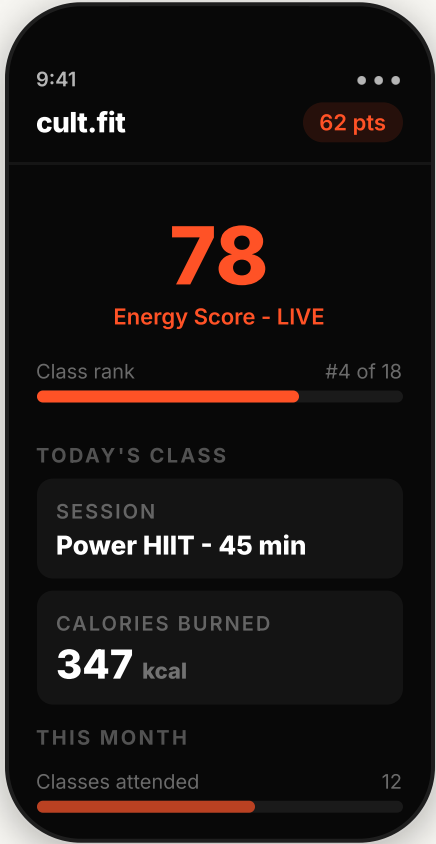
Fitness Journey gives history, not direction

"You've completed 12 HIIT sessions" - and then what? No AI recommendation for next workout, no progression plan. Passive tracking without a next step is a missed retention lever every month.

OPPORTUNITY

Expert.fit AI could close the loop

An in-app coaching layer that parses fitness history, energy scores, and calorie data to recommend the next session would turn passive logging into active personalization - the category's missing product.



FEATURE ANALYSIS - EAT.FIT

Eat.fit solves the right nutrition problem but loses the order at the exact moment it should win - when the user is hungry and ready to pay.

Three genuinely strong features: calorie-transparent Individual Order, structured Meal Plan, and Dietician consultation. But hiding delivery time until checkout, removing menu search, and fixing weekly meal plans are individually small failures that collectively send high-intent users to Swiggy.

DIFFERENTIATOR

Macro transparency on every item

Calories, protein, carbs, and ingredients on every menu item. No Swiggy or Zomato competitor matches this depth for health-conscious users - a genuine, defensible product difference.

CRITICAL FLAW

Delivery time shown only after payment

A hungry user who doesn't see an ETA before paying will order from Swiggy. This single UX decision kills the highest-intent moment in the product. It is not a design tradeoff - it is a conversion disaster.

TABLE STAKES MISSING

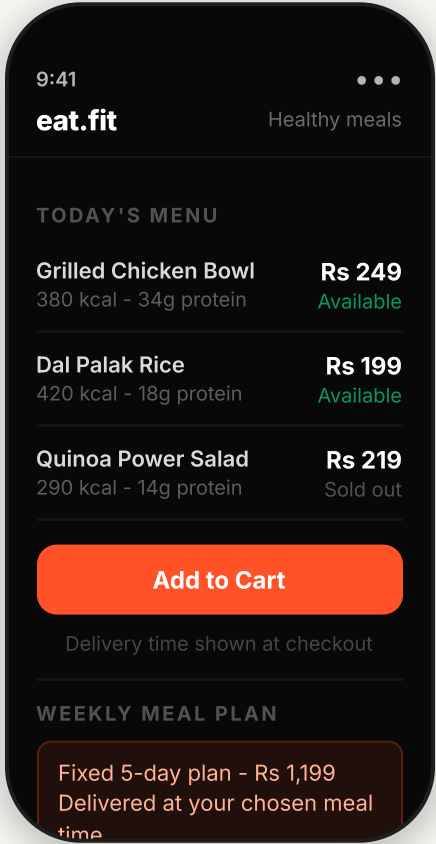
No menu search

To find "paneer," a user scrolls the full menu. Search is expected in every food app. Its absence is not a differentiator - it is a signal that the product team's attention is concentrated elsewhere.

OPPORTUNITY

Flexible weekly meal plan customization

Fixed weekly menus lose users with specific macros or dietary restrictions. A build-your-own plan with dynamic pricing expands the subscription market well beyond "healthy eating" early adopters.



FEATURE ANALYSIS - CARE.FIT

Care.Fit built the right stack for digital health - but trust, not features, sells a doctor. And "cult" is not a healthcare brand.

Care.Fit has doctor consults, therapy, at-home lab tests via Healthians, and supplements in one platform. The feature set is genuinely comprehensive. What it lacks is the signal that makes a user trust it with their actual health: verified doctor reviews, clinical credibility, and a brand that says "medical" rather than "gym."

FULL STACK COVERAGE

Doctor, therapy, labs, supplements

The vertical coverage is real: teleconsult, therapy sessions, at-home diagnostics via Healthians, and supplement upsells in one app. The architecture of the health OS is here - the trust layer is not.

MISSING - CRITICAL

No doctor review mechanism

Practo has millions of verified patient reviews. Care.Fit has zero. In a trust-critical purchase - choosing a doctor - the absence of social proof is not a UX gap. It is a reason not to book. Conversion rate reflects this directly.

MISSING

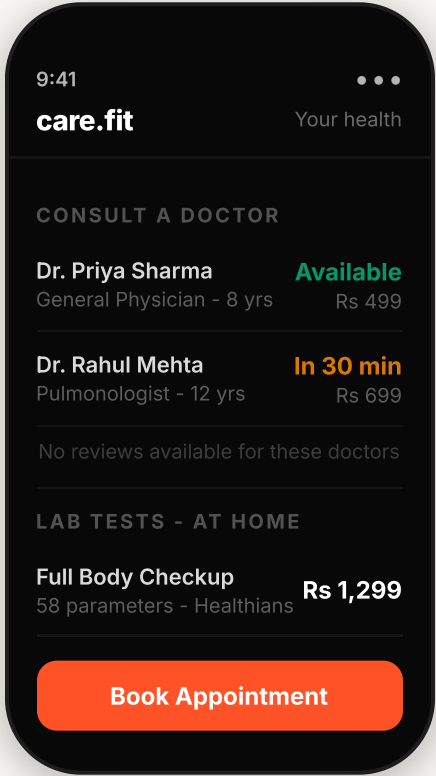
Recipe ingredient search

The Recipes section shows healthy meals but has no "search by ingredients I have" filter. Adding this turns a content section into a daily-use feature that drives Wellness tab opens between appointments.

THE BRAND MISMATCH

"Cult" means gym, not doctor

The 2021 rebrand sharpened the fitness identity but weakened the healthcare signal. Users seeking medical care are unlikely to start searching in an app they know as their gym. The brand gap is strategic, not tactical.



ACT 04

The Escape

04

STRATEGIC PIVOT

Dropping "Cure" for "Cult" was an admission: fitness is the only vertical where the brand earns trust without needing to explain itself.

The 2021 rebrand from Cure.Fit to Cult.Fit signaled a clear-eyed decision: the company's strongest brand equity is the gym, not the health platform. "Cult" has cultural resonance in India's fitness community. "Cure" implied a medical promise the product couldn't fully own against Practo and Apollo.

WHAT IT GOT RIGHT

Fitness-first positioning is credible

Cult.Fit centers, the Energy Meter mechanic, group class formats, and Cult.Live all carry the "Cult" identity authentically. The brand doubled down on its strongest asset and the market responded with clearer recognition.

WHAT IT COST

Healthcare credibility diluted

Care.Fit, Mind.fit, and medical consultation products now sit under a fitness brand. A user who needs a doctor is not starting their search in a gym app. The rebrand resolved the brand question but not the healthcare acquisition problem.

THE UNRESOLVED QUESTION

Health OS or fitness company?

The rebrand chose a direction without completing the strategic pivot. The company still runs 6 verticals. The health OS thesis still requires all 6 to win. The market is still asking: what, exactly, is this?

DIGITAL PRODUCT STRATEGY

Cult.Live is the escape hatch that survives center closures - but at lower ARPU, with worse retention, competing against free.

At Rs 499-999/month for unlimited live and on-demand classes, Cult.Live decouples the brand from geography and infrastructure. The real opportunity is not replacing offline - it is reaching Tier-2 and Tier-3 India where no center will ever open.

THE UPSIDE

Zero marginal cost beyond the first stream

1M or 5M digital subscribers runs on the same trainer and streaming infrastructure. Unlike a 270-center physical network, unit economics improve dramatically at scale. No lease renewals. No trainer payroll per location.

THE RISK

Home workouts have far worse retention

Cult.Fit centers had built-in accountability - a booked slot, a trainer expecting you, 18 peers showing up. At-home fitness subscriptions have structurally higher dropout. The product that survived COVID is harder to retain than the one it replaced.

THE REAL SCALE PLAY

Tier-2 and Tier-3 India - no center required

270 centers exist across 18 cities. Jaipur, Lucknow, Coimbatore, Bhopal - cities where no Cult.Fit center will open for years - have millions of health-conscious urban millennials who can buy Cult.Live today. This is the addressable market expansion the rebrand enables.

B2B EXPANSION

Corporate wellness is Cult.Fit's cleanest path to CAC efficiency - but the B2B product doesn't exist yet, only the B2B sales motion.

Cult.Fit Business offers bulk employee wellness subscriptions to corporates. One enterprise deal onboards 500 users at near-zero individual CAC. Post-COVID, HR budgets for employee wellness in India grew ~40% in 2021. The market is ready. The product is not.

THE UNIT ECONOMICS**500 employees, one deal, Rs 0 performance spend**

A 500-person corporate deal at Rs 1,200/employee/month generates Rs 7.2L/month recurring revenue with no Google or Meta spend. ARPU per acquired user is 60-70% of consumer ARPU - offset entirely by the zero-CAC advantage.

THE MISSING LAYER**No B2B product - only a B2C product sold in bulk**

There is no HR admin dashboard, no group challenge mechanics, no usage reporting for managers, no department leaderboards. The current product was built entirely for individual consumers. Enterprise renewal decisions need a tool for the buyer, not just the user.

THE MARKET TIMING**Corporate wellness mandates post-COVID**

Mental and physical wellness program budgets in India grew ~40% in 2021 according to HR industry surveys. Cult.Fit is the only integrated platform with gym + digital + nutrition to pitch as a complete employee benefit. The window to own this category is open right now.

ACT 05

PM Take

05

MOVE 1 - SHIP IN 60 DAYS

Fix the five UX failures that kill high-intent conversions today - no new features, no new infrastructure, just what is provably broken.

Every failure identified in this teardown is a revenue leak, not a roadmap debate. These ship in 60 days on the existing stack. No new team, no new approval chain, no external dependency. Each fix has an estimable, defensible impact on conversion.

EAT.FIT - CRITICAL

Surface delivery time on the menu page

Move the ETA from post-checkout to the menu browse screen. This is a single data field surfaced 30 seconds earlier in the user flow. Zero backend change required. Expected lift on first-order completion: 15-25% based on food delivery industry benchmarks.

EAT.FIT - HIGH

Add menu search + bottom-nav category popup

A search bar requires indexing existing menu data - no new data model. A bottom-right category popup is a standard navigation pattern already used in comparable apps in the Cult stack. Combined, this removes the primary reason users abandon menu browsing.

CARE.FIT - HIGH

Add a verified post-consult review module

Text review + star rating submitted only after a completed consult. The UI component exists in Cult Sports product reviews - reuse it, point it at Care.Fit doctors. Builds the trust signal that Practo has spent 10 years accumulating. One sprint to ship.

MOVE 2 - 3 TO 6 MONTHS

Build the B2B layer that makes HR managers Cult.Fit's best distribution channel - without it, the corporate wellness bet stays a sales motion, not a product.

The corporate wellness opportunity has the right economics and the right market timing. What it needs is a product layer built for the buyer - the HR manager who approves budget renewals - not just the end user who attends classes.

HR ADMIN DASHBOARD

Usage metrics that justify the renewal

Enrollment rates, average weekly sessions, department-level wellness scores, and top 10 most active employees. Reportable metrics that give the HR sponsor a slide for their leadership review. No dashboard means no data-driven renewal conversation.

GROUP CHALLENGES

Department vs. department streak battles

Marketing vs. Engineering 30-day step or class challenge. Social accountability within office social graphs. The engagement mechanic is zero incremental content cost - it uses existing Cult.Live sessions. Drives DAU up without a single new feature beyond the trigger.

CROSS-VERTICAL BUNDLING

Eat.fit credits baked into the corporate plan

Corporate plan includes monthly Eat.fit meal credits and Whole.Fit supplement allowance. Cross-vertical upsell becomes a line item in the B2B contract - not a user-level conversion. Increases ARPU per corporate user without any new consumer acquisition effort.

MOVE 3 - 12 TO 18 MONTHS

Build the longitudinal health data layer – the one asset no single-vertical competitor can replicate from scratch in under 5 years.

Cult.Fit's real moat is not the gym, the food delivery, or the doctor. It is the longitudinal health data from all three together - workout intensity, diet quality, and clinical metrics tracked for the same user over years. No competitor has this stack. No one can buy it. Build the AI layer that uses it.

THE DATA ASSET

Workout + nutrition + clinical in one graph

A user who does Cult HIIT, orders Eat.fit meals, and gets a Care.Fit lab test generates a multi-dimensional health profile no insurer, hospital, or fitness app can match. 10M registered users across six verticals is a dataset the market cannot replicate.

EXPERT.FIT AI COACH

Active prescription from six passive data sources

An AI layer that parses fitness history, meal patterns, lab results, energy scores, and sleep data to recommend next workouts, meal swaps, and when to see a doctor. This turns Cult.Fit from a transaction platform into a health intelligence platform - Cult's answer to Noom and Apple Health at once.

THE B2B DATA MONETIZATION PLAY

Anonymized profiles as a second revenue stream

Aggregated, anonymized longitudinal health data is materially valuable to insurers pricing wellness-adjusted premiums and to pharma companies running observational research. A health OS with 10M longitudinal profiles is a B2B asset worth more than any single subscription vertical - and no competitor can build it from scratch.

FINAL SYNTHESIS

Cult.Fit's best product isn't the gym. It's the data from doing all six things together.

Fix UX leaks - 60 days

B2B2C corporate layer - 6 months

Health data AI engine - 18 months

COVID exposed the fragility of a \$650M bet on offline infrastructure. Cult.Live and the B2B wellness push are the right direction - but neither fully realizes the health OS thesis. The real move is the data layer: a user who works out, eats, and gets care on one platform generates a health profile no competitor can buy or build in time. Fix the UX failures today. Build the corporate product in 6 months. Launch the data engine before someone else does. That is how Cult.Fit escapes the trap it built for itself.